

We'll shortly consider some ways of responding to Edwards' argument. But first let's think about how Edwards' argument might be related to an argument for fatalism.

There are truths
about our future
actions.

In the past, God
had
foreknowledge of
our future
actions.

We started off with two arguments for the reality of fate.

We have no
choice about the
past.

Let's turn to our last line of response to the two arguments. This is to deny the assumption, common to both arguments, that we have no choice about the past.

The denial of this assumption is often associated with William of Ockham, an English philosopher and theologian who was born about 15 years after Aquinas' death, in 1288. (He's the one that "Ockham's razor" is named after.)



To see why this might not be ridiculous, consider the overlooked philosophical problem of the incompatibility of free will and roommate true belief.

It seems that sometimes, your roommate can have true beliefs about what you will do; for example, the following might be true:

At 10 am today, your roommate
believed that you would eat a salad
for lunch.

Now imagine that at noon you are in the dining hall, about to grab a salad, when you are suddenly overcome with an unlikely desire for a fish sandwich. Do you have a choice about whether you will choose the salad or the fish sandwich? It seems that you do. **But then it also seems that you have a choice about whether your roommate's belief, at 10 am, was true.** After all, if you choose the fish sandwich, your roommate's belief that you would eat a salad will have been false.

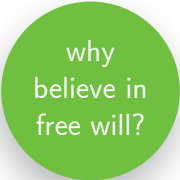
If this story makes sense, it follows that you do sometimes have a choice about past facts: you had a choice about whether, in the past, a certain belief about your future actions was true.



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

for fatalsn.

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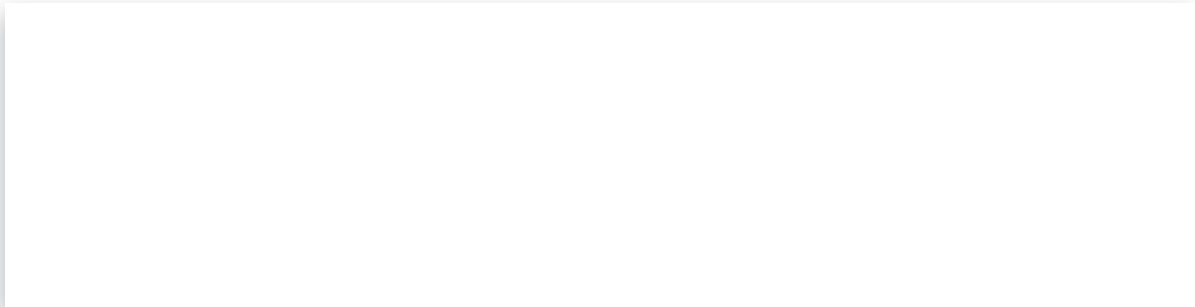
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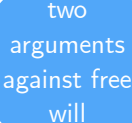
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Suppose that someone did not believe in

there were truths about all our future

God— and hence rejected premise (2) of

similar to Edwards' argument?

Edwards' argument — but did believe that

actions. Could they give an argument

replace reference to God's foreknowledge

(5) Let's look at what happens if we

God only shows up in premises (2) and

our future actions.

with reference to the being of truth about



all of our activities.

choice about the fact that if p , then q ,

2* In the past, there were truths about

3 We have not the fact that

then we have the choice about q.

God knows that in the future I will

1. We have no direct facts.

acaiiOId.



some action, then I will prefer that

that if it is true that I will perform

4. If we have no choice about p , and no

perform a certain action (1,2)

5* We have noticed that the fact

will perform various actions.

0 We have achieved what we

(3, 4, 5)

The fatalist argument

that Predict did not **take away** their free will; it just shows them that they

a Predictor. By the above line of thought, this person would lack free will. But

never had any. So they lacked free will before getting a Predicto.

So now consider a possible scenario in which someone exactly like you would get

But this person was stipulated to be exactly like you. So you don't have free will,

either.

and the example of the Predictor — which seem to show that if there is such a

things as fate, then there is no free will.

So far we've looked at two imaginary thought experiments—the story of Osmo,

Our question is: do either fatigue or foreknowledge pose a

serious challenge to the reality of free will?

Our first topic today is the oldest challenge to the existence of free will: the challenge to

freedom that comes from fate.

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